



# Birmingham River Champion's Group Volunteer Information Sheet

## Overview

Birmingham River Champions (BRC) is a citizen science project led by the University of Birmingham, working in support of the Environment Agency, Birmingham and Black Country Wildlife Trust, and Severn Trent's river ranger team.

We are connecting with volunteer groups delivering conservation work across the West Midlands, providing the training and equipment to monitor different aspects of river health. We suggest groups commit about 1-2 hours per month alongside their normal volunteering activities. See our website for more information on the project.

## Summary of Volunteer Group Lead Responsibilities

- Register their organisation with the BRC using the [online sign up form](#)
- Circulate resources sent after the group's registration to volunteers under their direction
- Upload the citizen science data via [our online form](#)
- If wishing to withdraw your organisation, email the BRC project team.

## BRC Monitoring and Participation

Volunteer group leads can register their organisation with the BRC using the [online sign up form](#). Volunteer group leads should circulate the ['Individual Volunteers' sign up form](#) and the 'Individual Volunteers' document to their volunteers. All volunteers in the BRC project must be over the age of 18. Groups wishing to collect Urban Riverfly and water chemistry sampling (i.e., needing access to the river) must clarify that they have safe access to shallow sections of river (see the risk assessment).

Volunteer group leads should consider the physical demands of the different monitoring techniques. The most exhaustive exercise is the 3-minute 'kick sample' in Urban Riverfly, but only one volunteer per group needs to do this (ideally the same person each time). The other physical actions required during BRC monitoring includes bending down to sample water and walking along riverbanks. Volunteer group leads can choose to participate in whichever monitoring technique they feel physically and mentally able to undertake.

We aim to supply one equipment set to each BRC-registered volunteer group, but if uptake is high then certain groups may be asked to share equipment. Individuals making up the group's sampling team (including the group leads) can vary between dates, and those attending should only do so when they are free and willing to participate.



Birmingham River Champions



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# Birmingham River Champion's Individual Volunteer Information Sheet

We advise that volunteer groups should repeat Urban Riverfly and water chemistry sampling every month where possible. Any volunteer undertaking BRC monitoring can upload citizen science data via our online form. Volunteer group leads may be contacted by the BRC project team regarding the data uploaded, and could remove any data from our records if deemed necessary.

Volunteer group leads can withdraw their organisation from the BRC at any point by emailing the BRC project team, who will then sortfield kit returns and ask whether the group's data can remain publicly visible on our app. Individuals associated with a BRC-registered volunteer group can withdraw from the initiative at any time by informing the BRC project team, who will then remove their name and email address from our records (see below for further information).

## Privacy Information

When signing up to the BRC, volunteer group leads will provide their name, their volunteer group's name and volunteer group's email address. These will be stored in a passwordprotected electronic spreadsheet held by the BRC project leads in the University of Birmingham's secure OneDrive storage environment.

This information will be kept alongside two privacy preferences outlined during the sign up process:

- Whether they wish to subscribe to the BRC mailing list, where subscribers will receive emails containing useful information, help and updates on the project (at roughly monthly to quarterly intervals). Any volunteer group leads using their personal email address should bear this privacy information in mind, but are free to subscribe or unsubscribe at any point.
- Whether the volunteer group leads want their organisation's name and / or email address (not that of the lead individual) to be displayed on our **publicly visible website**.

## Health and Safety

Health and safety is of paramount importance and every individual within a volunteer group undertaking BRC monitoring should comply with the following health and safety procedures. Volunteers should ensure they have read and understood the health and safety information below and a separate risk assessment provided before undertaking monitoring.



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Once that you are signed up to the BRC project, you will be covered by the University's public liability insurance and employers liability insurance when monitoring.

Please follow the following guidance when completing any surveying:

- When working in or near water. never work alone. Always have another person in attendance.
- Only access water at easy-to-access locations.
- Only sample at locations where water is below welly height.
- Check riverbed before entering to ensure stable materials are underfoot.
- Please check the weather forecast before you sample.
- If water levels rise rapidly, abort sampling immediately.
- Check for and avoid any sharp and cumbersome materials and any potentially dangerous or hazardous features (e.g., needles, syringes) in the water.
- Check for and avoid giant hogweed along riverbanks (its sap can cause nasty burns), and any other toxic plants whilst monitoring.
- Broken skin should be covered with a waterproof dressing.
- Hands should be washed after sampling and before eating, drinking or smoking to reduce chances of illness.
- Practising good sanitation is important for reducing the chances of contracting Weils disease (or Leptospirosis).
- Extra precautions (e.g., wearing disposable gloves) should be adopted when sampling rivers surrounded by pasture that likely contain animal urine.
- Wear long sleeved clothing when walking through grassy or woodland areas and check for ticks after sampling.
- Be aware of the symptoms of Lyme Disease and seek medical attention if any symptoms are present.
- Extra caution should be exercised when undertaking water chemistry sampling as some techniques use dangerous solutions.

Further information on all of this health and safety information can be found within the BRC risk assessment that will be emailed to all volunteer group leads and volunteers under their direction.

If you have any questions about the project please contact Dr James C. White at [birminghamriverchampions@gmail.com](mailto:birminghamriverchampions@gmail.com)

For enquiries on your participation or privacy information, please contact the University of Birmingham's Research Ethics team [ethics-queries@contacts.bham.ac.uk](mailto:ethics-queries@contacts.bham.ac.uk).



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